inside an abandoned Garmsir school.

Small gravel courtyard, corrugated tin roof. Someone said the school had been an agricultural university. Someone else said it had been a madrassa. For the moment, however, it was a part of the British Commonwealth. And my new home.

It was also home to a company of Gurkhas.

Recruited from Nepal, from the remotest villages along the foothills of the Himalayas, the Gurkhas had fought in every British war of the last two centuries, and distinguished themselves in each one. They scrapped like tigers, never gave up, and as a result they held a special place in the British Army—and in my heart. I'd been hearing about the Gurkhas since I was a boy: one of the first uniforms I'd ever worn was a Gurkha uniform. At Sandhurst the Gurkhas always played the enemy in military exercises, which always felt a bit ridiculous because they were beloved.

After the exercises a Gurkha would invariably walk up to me and offer me a cup of hot chocolate. They had a solemn reverence for royalty. A king, to their minds, was divine. (Their own king was believed to be the reincarnated Hindu god Vishnu.) A prince, therefore, wasn't far off. I'd felt this growing up, but now felt it again. As I walked through Delhi, the Gurkhas all bowed. They called me *saab*.

Yes, saab. No, saab.

I pleaded: Don't. I'm just Lieutenant Wales. I'm just Widow Six Seven.

They laughed. *No chance, saab.*

Neither would they have dreamed of allowing me to go anywhere by myself. Royal persons required royal escort. Often I'd be headed to the mess, or the loo, and suddenly become aware of a shadow on my right. Then another on my left. *Hello, saab.* It was embarrassing, albeit touching. I adored them, as did the local Afghans, who sold the Gurkhas many chickens and goats and even bantered with them about recipes. The Army talked a lot about winning Afghan "hearts and minds," meaning converting locals to democracy and freedom, but only the Gurkhas seemed to be actually doing it.